ROBIN YIFAN LUO

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EDUCATION

University of Washington, Seattle, Ph.D. in Finance *Expected June 2027*

University of British Columbia, M.Sc. in Finance *2021*

Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, M.Sc. in Economics *2019*

University of Nottingham (China – UK), B.Sc. with Honours in Economics *2018*

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Financial Intermediation, Corporate Finance, Industrial Organization

JOB MARKET PAPER

Misallocation in Banking, solo-authored *Draft available upon request*

I develop and estimate a two-sided oligopolistic model of U.S. banking to measure how uneven bank pricing power misallocates deposits and loans. Estimated misallocation falls over time, with deposit-loan complementarities offsetting a substantial share. The framework also evaluates how competition, mergers, monetary tightening, and banking stress shift banks relative to efficient allocation benchmarks.

PUBLICATION

In Search of a Unicorn: Dynamic Agency with Endogenous Investment Opportunities, with Felix Zhiyu Feng and Beatrice Michaeli

Journal of Accounting and Economics, 2024. [SSRN]

We develop a dynamic contracting model in which privately observed opportunities arrive through costly search. The optimal contract generates time-varying investment thresholds, internal search charges, and empirically testable overinvestment patterns.

WORKING PAPERS

The Optimal Schedules of Incentives and Cash Flows, with Felix Zhiyu Feng and Mark M. Westerfield

We study delegated management when observable output combines investment in durable asset quality and instantaneous effort. Optimal incentives begin back-loaded and can become front-loaded as promised future incentives accumulate, generating cash-flow mean reversion and implications for the duration of incentives.

Clientele Specialization, Stable Capital, and Value in Asset Management, with Hossein Poorvasei

Using data on 4,391 U.S. separately managed account products, we document that clientele specialization predicts more durable funding, more stable exposures, and higher gross-of-fee alpha. A model links relationship-specific investment to funding stability, scale, and the division of gains between managers and clients.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Money-Market Capacity and the Funding Channel of Monetary Policy, with Germán Gutiérrez and Hossein Poorvasei

We show that the cost banks pay to replace deposits with wholesale funding during monetary tightening is not a fixed friction but depends on money-market capacity. It rises more steeply when capacity is scarce, only for unsecured funding, and passes through to bank lending.

The Industrial Organization of Safe Savings, with Germán Gutiérrez and Hossein Poorvasei

We show that deposit betas are equilibrium outcomes of a market in which differentiated bank products compete with money funds, Treasury bills, and cash. Estimating deposit demand for the universe of U.S. banks, we find that the pass-through of policy rates to the marginal value of deposit funding is far below one, and that competition within a bank's own product menu, more so than rivalry between banks, generates most of the observed pass-through.

Production Functions in Asset Management, with Ahmed Guecioueur

TEACHING AND STUDENT ENGAGEMENT

Teaching Assistant, University of Washington *2022–2026*

- EMBA 520: Financial Management, for Jonathan Karpoff
- EMBA 540: International Finance, for Stephan Siegel

Median rating of 4.7/5.0 across seven Executive MBA sections (range 4.5–4.9).
Recipient of EMBA Teaching Recognition Award.

PRESENTATIONS

Conferences and invited seminars (presented by coauthor)*

2026: Finance Theory Group Fall Meeting*, FMA Annual Meeting, FIRS Conference*, Econometric Society North American Summer Meeting*

2025: Financial Theory Group Summer School, Southwest Finance Association, Eastern Finance Association*

2023: CES North America Conference, Journal of Accounting and Economics conference*, Organizational Economics Workshop*, 33rd Stony Brook International Conference on Game Theory*

2022: Financial Markets and Corporate Governance Conference*, Research Symposium on Finance and Economics, Asia-Pacific Association of Derivatives, Australasian Finance & Banking Conference, China International Conference in Finance*, HKUST Accounting Research Symposium*

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Ph.D. Student Mentor, UW Foster *2024–2026*

Doctoral Business Students Association Representative, UW Foster *2025*

Co-Organizer, Finance Ph.D. Brownbag, UW Foster *2022–2024*

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Dean's Achievement Award, UW Foster
EMBA Teaching Recognition Award, UW Foster
UW Ph.D. Fellowship

SKILLS AND INTERESTS

Programming: R, MATLAB, Python, Stata, SQL, LaTeX
Languages: Mandarin (native), English (fluent), French (basic), Cantonese (basic)
Interests: Hiking, bouldering, concerts, acoustic guitar

REFERENCES

Mark M. Westerfield (Chair)
Professor of Finance and Business Economics, Michael G. Foster Endowed Professor
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